

Monodon monoceros

Narwhal



Length 12–16½ ft (3.7–5 m)
Weight ¾–1½ tons (0.7–1.8 tonnes)
Social unit Group
Status Near threatened

Location Arctic Ocean



The narwhal has the most northerly range of any mammal, among ice-fields and floes of Arctic waters. It has one ever-growing tooth, the upper-left incisor, which forms a long tusk (see panel, right). Fish, mollusks, crustaceans, and other prey are probably sucked into the mouth by the narwhal's powerful lips and tongue.

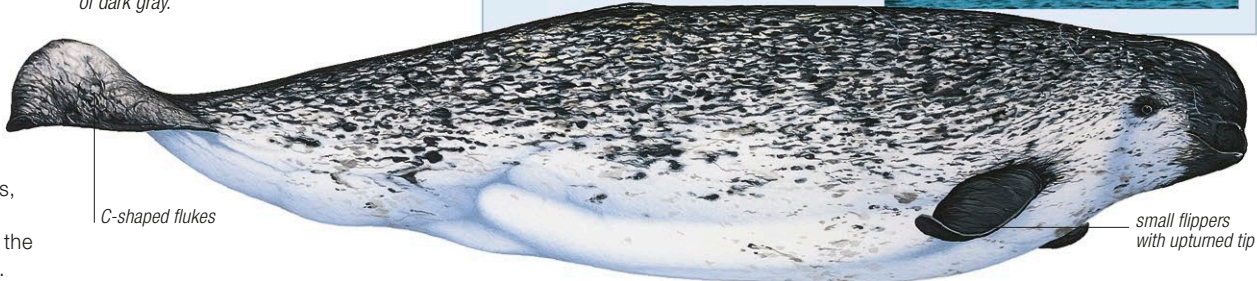
Like belugas—indeed, often with them—narwhals can sometimes form large schools of thousands, which may be segregated by age and sex. They communicate with a wide variety of sounds, including humlike tones that may be for individual recognition.

COLORATION

The narwhal (female pictured here) is speckled gray and black on a pale background, with more patches on the back merging into larger areas of dark gray.

MALE NARWHAL'S TUSK

The narwhal's tusk grows with age, through the upper lip, spiraling clockwise, to reach 9½ ft (3 m) long. It may be used as a weapon by rival males at breeding time, but recent findings indicate that it has a sensory function. Any use in feeding seems unlikely, since most females lack tusks. Some males have 2 tusks, and some females have one.



Phocoena phocoena

Harbor porpoise



Length ½–6½ ft (41.4–2 m)
Weight 99–165 lb (45–75 kg)
Social unit Variable
Status Least concern

Location North Pacific, North Atlantic, Black Sea



The most numerous cetacean over much of its range, the harbor porpoise has nevertheless suffered, like other inshore sea creatures, as a result of human activity. A major danger is

being snared in underwater fishing nets when, as an air-breather, it asphyxiates. Apart from humans, its main predators are killer whales, bottlenose dolphins, and large sharks. The harbor porpoise generally forages alone, in waters down to 655 ft (200 m), for seabed dwellers such as fish and shellfish. It uses very high-pitched echolocation and grips prey with its spade-shaped teeth, numbering 19–28 pairs in the upper and lower jaws. Groups usually form because prey such as schooling fish are particularly rich in small areas. The single calf is born in early summer and cared for by the mother for up to 12 months.

Phocoena sinus

Vaquita



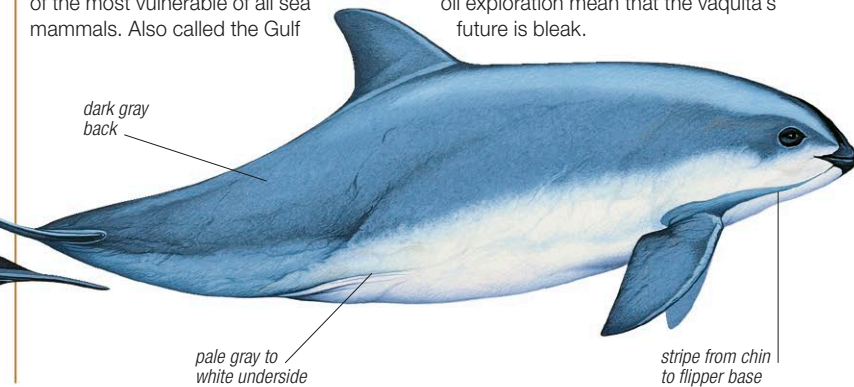
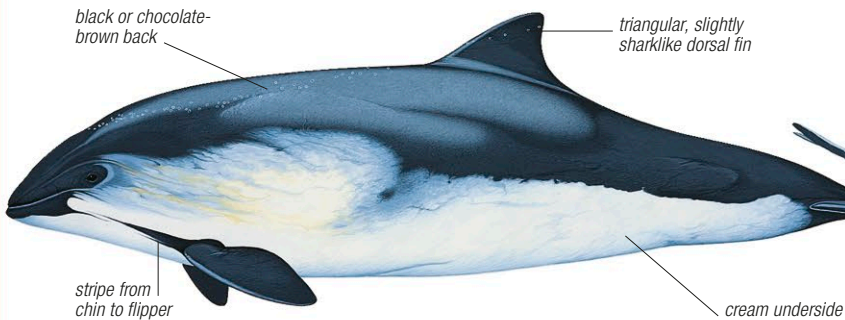
Length 4–5 ft (1.2–1.5 m)
Weight 66–105 lb (30–48 kg)
Social unit Variable
Status Critically endangered

Location Gulf of California



This small porpoise's very restricted range, in shallow waters less than 130 ft (40 m) deep at the northern end of the Gulf of California, makes it one of the most vulnerable of all sea mammals. Also called the Gulf

of California porpoise, its habits are little known. It is usually solitary, or in groups of 2–4, but may also form groups of up to 10 if food is plentiful. It takes a mixed diet of small fish, squid, and other prey on or near the sea bed, and uses high-frequency clicks for echolocation. The main body color is gray, darker above than below and also around the eyes and mouth. The calf is only 28–32 in (70–80 cm) long at birth and is suckled by the mother for several months. Illegal fishing has reduced populations by 92 percent since the mid 90s, and only an estimated 60 individuals are left. Also, threats such as entanglement in fishing nets, pollution, boat noise, and oil exploration mean that the vaquita's future is bleak.



Neophocaena phocaenoides

Indo-pacific Finless porpoise



Length 4½–5½ ft (1.4–1.7 m)
Weight 65–120 lb (30–55 kg)
Social unit Variable
Status Vulnerable

Location Indian Ocean, W. Pacific



Lack of a dorsal fin makes this medium-sized porpoise difficult to identify, or even see, because it surfaces briefly and

rolls gently while taking breaths. The vaguely dolphinlike bulging forehead and a slightly beaked snout make it distinctive among the 7 porpoise species. The finless porpoise frequents coastal waters around the Indian and West Pacific oceans, including

estuaries and up rivers. Like other porpoises (and unlike dolphins), it leaps from the water only rarely, yet it may “spyhop” in the manner of whales, holding its body vertically, half out of the water, as though standing up to

look around. It feeds alone or in groups of up to 6, more if food is plentiful. Small fish, mollusks, and crustaceans on or near the seabed are caught using the 13–22 pairs of spade-shaped teeth in both upper and lower jaws.

